

testdisk byte for byte backup to dd ubuntu

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To create a byte-for-byte backup of a drive for data recovery in Ubuntu, you use the standard Linux **dd** command to create an image file. This copies every sector—including deleted files and empty space—to a safe location, which you can then safely scan with TestDisk.

1. Identify Your Drives

Before doing anything, use **lsblk** to find the exact drive letters for both your **source drive** and your **backup drive** (the drive where the image file will be saved).

```
lsblk
```

*(Note: Your source drive might look like **/dev/sdb**, and your backup drive's partition might be mounted at **/mnt/backup**.)*

2. Unmount the Drives

To avoid data corruption, ensure the source drive is not currently mounted. If any partitions are mounted, unmount them using the backup partition's mount point or the drive's partition identifier:

```
sudo umount /dev/sdb1
```

3. Run the **dd** Command

To create the byte-for-byte backup, use the following **dd** command syntax:

```
sudo dd if=/dev/source_drive of=/path/to/backup/drive/image_name.img  
status=progress
```

- **if=** (input file) is the raw source drive (e.g., **/dev/sdb**—do not add a partition number like **sdb1** unless you only want one partition).
- **of=** (output file) is the file path on your external/backup drive.

Tip for failing drives: If the drive is failing or has bad sectors, add `conv=noerror,sync` to force `dd` to push through the errors without freezing:

```
sudo dd if=/dev/source_drive of=/path/to/backup/drive/image_name.img  
conv=noerror,sync status=progress
```

4. Scan the Image with TestDisk

Once the `dd` image is created, you can safely scan that `.img` file with TestDisk without altering your original hardware.

If you don't have it installed, run:

```
sudo apt install testdisk
```

Then point TestDisk directly at your image file:

```
sudo testdisk /path/to/backup/drive/image_name.img
```